Lobsters

Lobsters, together with crabs, shrimps, prawns, and crayfish, are all known as crawlers, because of their movement. They live on the seashore, seabed, and in streams. Lobsters have large pincers for defence and feeding. The male's pincers are usually larger than the female's. The biggest species is the blue lobster, which weighs up to 25 kg (55 lb). Crayfish, close relatives of the lobster, live in freshwater and tend to be smaller.

Environments

Lobsters prefer an environment featuring many nooks and crannies. Their ideal hiding place is a sandy burrow under a rock.

Lobster backing into its burrow.

Defence

Lobsters can evade capture by discarding a limb. There is a special "breaking plane" near the base of the leg that, when twisted, causes the leg to snap off. The wound soon heals and a new limb starts growing immediately.

Common lobster adopting a defensive pose

Lobster march

In an extraordinary event known as the lobster march, hundreds of lobsters gather and walk one after the other for more than 100 km (60 miles) across the seabed. It is possible that they are looking for a suitable area to settle, with an adequate supply of food. The lobsters make sounds during their migration and it is thought that these are noises of communication that help co-ordinate the journey. This event has not been seen in any of the other larger crustacean groups.

Spiny lobsters

Water fleas

Water fleas, a group that includes brine and fairy shrimp, all breathe through leaf-shaped gills on their feet. Apart from brine shrimp (which live in saline pools), water fleas inhabit freshwater. Fairy shrimp live in temporary puddles. When these dry up, their eggs become airborne until they fall into another pool.

Daphnia water flea

Cleaner-shrimps

Brightly coloured and easily recognizable cleaner-shrimps remove external scale and gill parasites from passing fish, such as the goby – and even remove unswallowed food particles from within the fish's mouth. Both animals benefit from this association, which is known as "cleaner symbiosis". Other symbiotic relationships exist between shrimps and sponges, sea anemones, and corals.

Cleaner-shrimp

Shrimps

The world's seas are full of scavenging shrimps and prawns. They look similar but prawns have a pointed rostrum (a saw-like structure at the front of the body) and two pairs of pincers, while shrimps have only one pair. Krill, small shrimp-like animals that live in the Antarctic seas, form the main food of whales.

Growth of shrimps

Most crustaceans, including shrimps, are unable to increase in size because their exoskeleton (shell) is inflexible. Therefore, they moult their shells at regular intervals. The new soft exposed skin underneath hardens quickly to form another, larger shell.

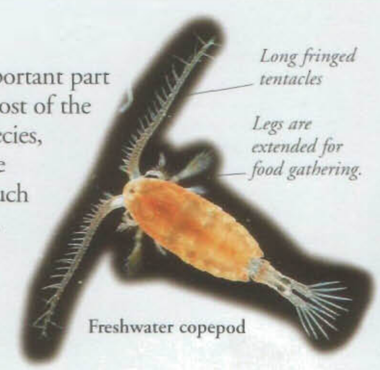
Strawberry shrimp

Mussel shrimp

The tiny mussel or seed shrimp (so-called because its carapace is made up of two shells, like that of a mussel) produces the largest sperms in the animal kingdom. The 0.3-mm (0.01-in) long male of one species produces sperms 20 times its own length.

Copepods

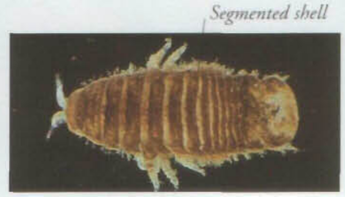
These tiny creatures are an important part of plankton, which provides most of the world's fish with food. One species, *Calanus finmarchicus,* forms the staple diet of open-sea fishes, such as herring, sprat, and mackerel. Others, however, are parasitic and live in or on worms, molluscs, other crustaceans, fish, and whales.



Freshwater copepod

Gribble

Able to digest wood, the gribble bores into the submerged wooden supports of jetties, wharfs, bridges, and pilings. It can turn these structures into a pulpy mass, causing them to collapse.



SPINY SPIDER CRAB
SCIENTIFIC NAME *Machrocheira kaempferi*
SUBCLASS Malacostraca
ORDER Decapoda
DISTRIBUTION Seas around Japan
HABITAT On the seabed
DIET Scavenges anything edible from the seabed – an omnivore, it eats meat and plant matter
SIZE Span claw-to-claw 3.6 m (11 ft)
LIFESPAN Unknown, but lobsters, a relative, have lived up to 70 years in captivity

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